



I HAVE WORKED TO DISCHARGE HEAVEN'S WILL

HONGWU FOUNDS THE MING DYNASTY (1368)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Ming China

BEFORE

1279 Kublai Khan overthrows the Song and establishes the Mongol Yuan dynasty.

1344 In central China, the Yellow River begins to shift course, leading to droughts and a subsequent upsurge in peasant rebellions.

1351 Outbreak of Red Turban revolt against the Yuan.

AFTER

1380 Hongwu takes on the role of chief minister, laying the basis of an authoritarian political culture.

1415 Yongle revives and extends the Grand Canal, enabling it to carry goods from southern China to Beijing.

1520 The first Portuguese trading missions to China.

c. 1592 Publication of *Journey to the West*, one of the masterworks of Chinese classical writing.

1644 Chongzhen dies by suicide, ending the Ming era.

Military and economic decline under the late Yuan dynasty leads to **widespread peasant revolts**.



Hongwu founds the Ming dynasty and institutes reforms that restore stability, and also give the emperor absolute authority.



Autocratic, highly centralized system provides centuries of stable rule and economic prosperity.



A series of **weak rulers** means centralized system ceases to operate efficiently.



Ming dynasty collapses in the face of Manchu invasion and peasant uprisings.

Surrounded by officials at the imperial palace in Nanjing, Zhu Yuanzhang, the son of poor peasant farmers, offered sacrifices to Heaven and Earth as he was proclaimed first emperor of China's Ming ("brilliant") dynasty.

It was the culmination of a remarkable rise to power by the monk turned rebel general, who had ousted the despised Yuan